

38 Korah

The Levite who led a revolt against Moses and Aaron and was swallowed by the earth.

Korah was a Levite of the family of Kohath, a cousin of Moses and Aaron. His family already carried the most holy furnishings of the tabernacle, but Korah wanted more. With Dathan, Abiram and 250 leaders of Israel, he accused Moses and Aaron of lifting themselves above God's people. The earth opened and swallowed the rebels' households, and fire consumed the 250 offering incense. Korah became a byword for rebellion. Yet his sons did not die, and their descendants gave their name to some of Israel's best-loved psalms.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Qorach</i> , possibly "bald"; KJV Core in Jude 11
Family	Son of Izhar, son of Kohath; cousin of Moses and Aaron
Allies	Dathan, Abiram, On and 250 princes (Numbers 16:1–2)
When	In the wilderness years; date not given
Descendants	The sons of Korah, temple singers and gatekeepers
Main passages	Numbers 16:1–50; 26:9–11
New Testament	Jude 11

"And they gathered themselves together against Moses and against Aaron, and said unto them, Ye take too much upon you, seeing all the congregation are holy, every one of them, and the LORD is among them: wherefore then lift ye up yourselves above the congregation of the LORD?"

Numbers 16:3, KJV

The life of Korah

Numbers does not date Korah's revolt. It is placed after the failure at Kadesh (Numbers 13–14), somewhere in the forty years of wandering. That period is c. 1445–1406 BC on the early Exodus date, or about 185 years later on the late date.

In Egypt	● Born a Kohathite Korah is born to Izhar, brother of Amram. So he is a first cousin of Moses, Aaron and Miriam. <i>Exodus 6:18, 21</i>
At Sinai	● Given holy work The Kohathites are appointed to carry the ark, the table, the lampstand and the altars when Israel travels. Only the priests may cover and handle these holy things. <i>Numbers 3:27–31; 4:1–20</i>
In the wilderness	● Leads a revolt With Dathan, Abiram, On and 250 well-known leaders, he confronts Moses and Aaron: "Ye take too much upon you." Moses falls on his face. <i>Numbers 16:1–4</i>
The next day	● The test of the censers Moses tells Korah's company to come back with censers, fire and incense, so the LORD can show who is his. Korah gathers the whole congregation at the tabernacle door, and God's glory appears. <i>Numbers 16:5–7, 16–19</i>
That same day	● Judgment The ground splits open and swallows Dathan, Abiram and the households of Korah. Fire from the LORD consumes the 250 men offering incense. <i>Numbers 16:20–35; 26:10</i>

Group notes

Key activities

Numbers 16 weaves together two protests. Korah and his Levites wanted the priesthood. Dathan and Abiram rejected Moses' leadership. Numbers 16:32 says the earth swallowed "all the men that appertained unto Korah," but Numbers 26:11 adds that his sons did not die.

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- 1 Resented his place.** Though given holy work, he and his followers sought the priesthood as well. *Numbers 16:8-10*
 - 2 Gathered a following.** He drew 250 famous leaders of the congregation into his cause. *Numbers 16:1-2*
 - 3 Used true words wrongly.** He said all the congregation was holy, turning a true teaching into a weapon against God's chosen leaders. *Numbers 16:3; Exodus 19:6*
 - 4 Stood with his censer.** He gathered the whole congregation against Moses and Aaron at the door of the tabernacle. *Numbers 16:18-19*
 - 5 Was judged by God.** The earth opened, and the rebels "went down alive into the pit." *Numbers 16:31-33*
 - 6 Left a warning.** The censers of the 250 men were hammered into plates to cover the altar, as a memorial to Israel. *Numbers 16:36-40*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Korah.

Old Testament

Exodus 6:21, 24	His family line
Numbers 16:1–50	The revolt, the judgment, and the plague
Numbers 17:1–10	Aaron's rod buds to settle who is chosen
Numbers 26:9–11	"Notwithstanding the children of Korah died not"
Numbers 27:3	Zelophehad was not "in the company of Korah"
Psalms 106:16–18	Dathan and Abiram swallowed by the earth
Psalms 42; 44–49; 84–85; 87–88	Titled "for the sons of Korah"
1 Chronicles 6:33–38; 9:19	Heman the singer and gatekeepers descend from him

New Testament

Jude 11	False teachers "perished in the gainsaying of Core"
Echo: 2 Timothy 2:19	"The Lord knoweth them that are his" (Numbers 16:5)

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Korah and his followers accuse Moses and Aaron of (Numbers 16:3)?
2. *Understand:* The Levites already had great privilege (Numbers 16:9–10). Why was that not enough?
3. *Apply:* Where are you tempted to compare your role with someone else's?
4. *Apply:* Korah's sons became singers in God's house. What do you want to pass on?